

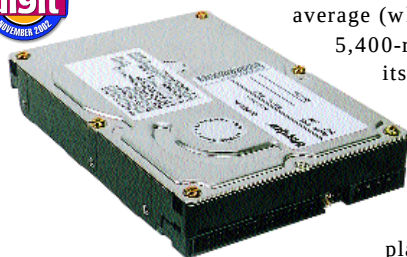
5 Things to Consider Before you Buy



- Speed or space? If you need to store MP3s and DivX films, or to back up heavy image files, buy the largest hard disk you can afford. On the other hand, if you extensively use applications such as image editing or audio processing software, look for the fastest hard disk you can afford—at least a 7,200-rpm drive—and buy the largest in that speed range.
- Research the market. Ask your friends or dealers you know, or search the Internet for information about the manufacturer, the reputation they enjoy and their after sales-service.
- Check the warranty. Apart from the time frame covered, also check the type of warranty. Some manufacturers will replace the hard disk only in the first year, after which they will only repair it. This is rather unreliable and can lead to more problems in the future.
- Confirm the time it takes to replace a faulty hard disk. This is especially important if your business relies heavily on data storage. Generally, manufacturers who run a service centre are able to provide quick replacements, while those who don't have service centres could take weeks to replace a faulty hard disk.
- Check for accessories such as IDE cables, disk management software and operating manuals.

keep power users happy. It performed exceptionally well in our synthetic and real world tests. In the read burst speed (HDTach) test, it hit a high score of 80 MBps. It also performed well in the application load time test, completing the test the quickest among this group of drives. If your time on the computer is spent in storing huge files and if you work with bandwidth-hungry applications such as Photoshop and 3DStudio Max, this drive will answer your needs.

The Maxtor D540X-4K is our Best Value Award winner with its good performance, features and competitive price. This 5400-rpm drive offers an impressive 80 GB storage space.



The Maxtor D540X-4K: Lots of storage at a great value

Though its performance was rather average (which is attributed to its 5,400-rpm rotational speed), its price gives it the edge.

This drive provides a disk management software called MaxBlast and the package includes mounting plates, screws, data cables,

a manual and a quick start guide. It is a good choice if you require a large capacity

drive without a very high level of performance.

We have yet again seen an iteration in hard disk drives over the past year. 40 GB drives are now entry level and performance is increasing with 7,200-rpm drives fast becoming the *de facto* standard. This, coupled with falling prices, will ensure that we have drives that will let us power the next generation of applications, operating systems and games, while not pinching the pocket. 

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